

DO IT OR BE DAMNED

Politically aware but not politically active. Insistent on change but not blinded by youth. Yearning for a strong hand, young India wants its leaders to be performers.

On a wintry morning somewhere in India, his day begins with a hot cup of coffee, a newspaper that rarely brings cheer to the reader, and a news channel that is equally depressing. Across the columns and on the screen, it's the same old stories that once more remind him of the strangeness of India, the shamelessness of its political class, the innate savagery of its society, and its petty deceptions. As he is about to hop the channel or flip the page with the customary

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yawn, there pops up a feel-good piece which finally forces a we-are-not-yet-damned from our man. Though generally an underwhelming experience, reading or watching political news does not tire him. He is interested. He wants to

know. He as a citizen has a stake in it. Still, guess who's spoiling the first hours of his day. The proverbial pol with a million platitudes. Is this all we can get from the world's most volatile democracy? He sighs as more of them in starched cotton,

spouting the familiar clichés, march before his eyes. We can't afford these guys. And most of them look as if they are escapees from a geriatric ward. We deserve better. Well, we need a Mrs G, the original. He misses the strong leader, and he thinks

Indira was the strongest of them all. India needs her, now. See what we have got. He is getting angry. Look at the prime minister. A gentleman indeed, and reassuringly professorial, but isn't there something missing in the man? Maybe polit-